

Feather-Handed Fascists

Surveillance as a Signal of Bureaucratic Alignment

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Motivation and Research Question

Want a job in the Trump administration? Be prepared for the loyalty test



Wall Street Journal

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- in Fascist Italy (1922-1940),
- who controlled the political police, tasked with surveilling potential dissidents.
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- ↓ bureaucratic **effort**: −18–22% surveilled individuals,
- ↑ **rewards**: +4-5 times increase in office retention per record,

due to signalling incentives.

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→ applies beyond autocratic politics or security (e.g. a fossil fuel-friendly administration staffing the EPA)

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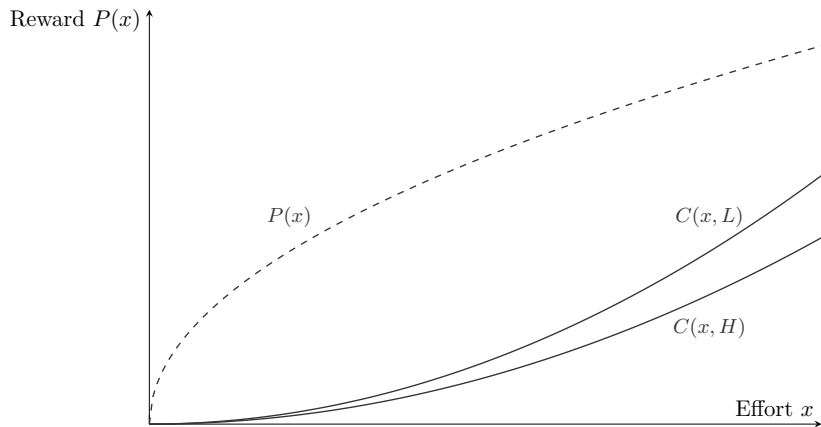
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The principal rewards them according to a technology, increasing and convex in x :

- *Pure Effort case*: $P(x)$, only effort is rewarded;
- *Signalling case*: $P(x, \mu)$, effort and revealed alignment μ are rewarded.

Equilibria



Equilibria

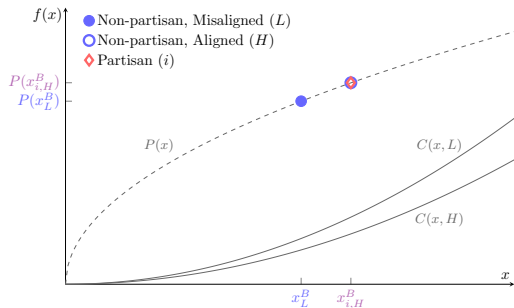


Figure 1: Pure Effort Equilibrium

Equilibria

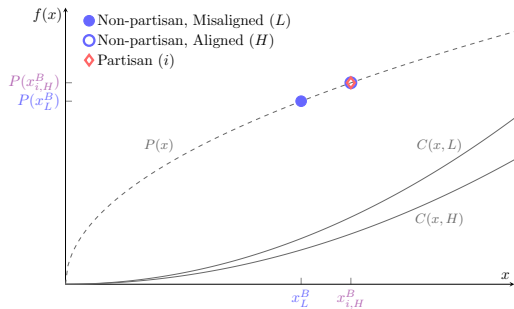


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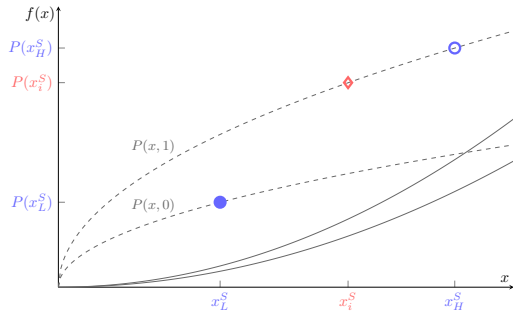


Figure 2: Signalling Equilibrium

Implication 1 - Effort levels

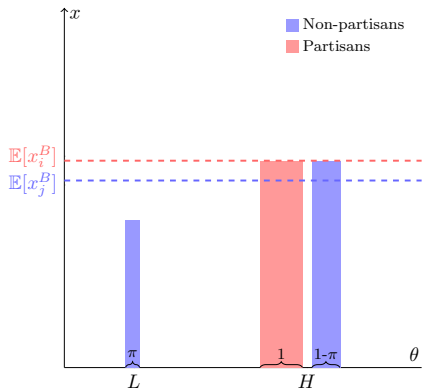


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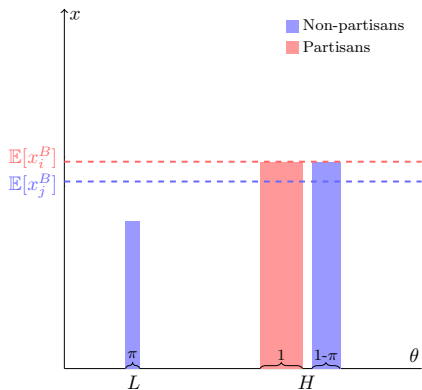


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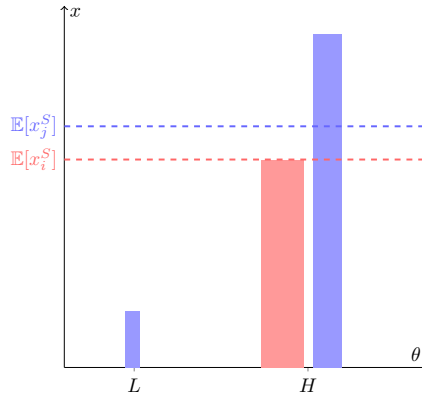


Figure 4: Signalling Equilibrium

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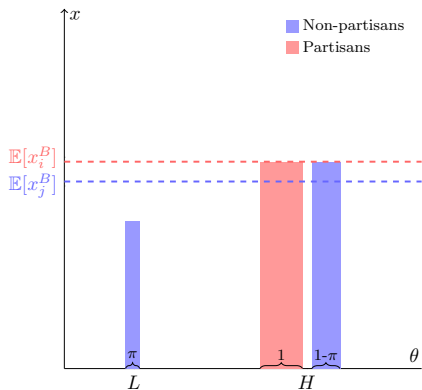


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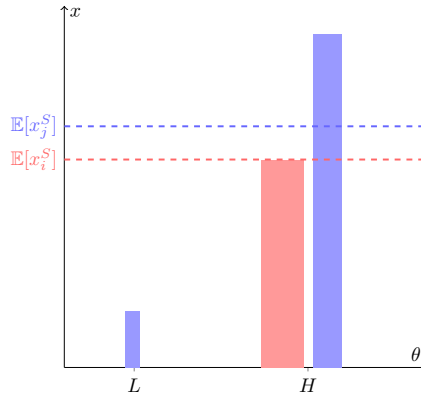


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Framing the literature

Pure Effort

Partisans are more aligned

⇒ they put more effort

- evidence from democracies:
 - Spenkuch, Teso, and Xu (2023) and Wirsching (2025) in the US,
 - Rivera (2020) in India;
- and from autocracies (Svolik 2012):
 - Scharpf and Gläbel (2020) in Argentina,
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Signalling

Partisans do not need to prove themselves

⇒ they put less effort

- Autocrat screens agents on performance (Montagnes and Wolton 2019)
- and agents that want to signal effectiveness overrepress (Luo and Zakharov 2025).
- Compatible evidence from China:
 - Qian and Bai (2024) and He and Wu (2026) in the Anti-Rightist Campaign,
 - Jia, Kudamatsu, and Seim (2015) on connections and performance as complements.

Case

History: Our agents

Prefects

- Office instituted by Napoleon,
- appointed by the Ministry of Interior,
- highest representative of executive power in the province,
- heavily relied on by the regime (> local party chiefs),
- with vast policing powers:
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In fact, these [dissidents] are often 'invented' subversives, found among the dense ranks of people who were not socially integrated.

(People dangerous to the security of the State (1872-1983), Questura di Bologna, p. 7)

History: Partisan prefects

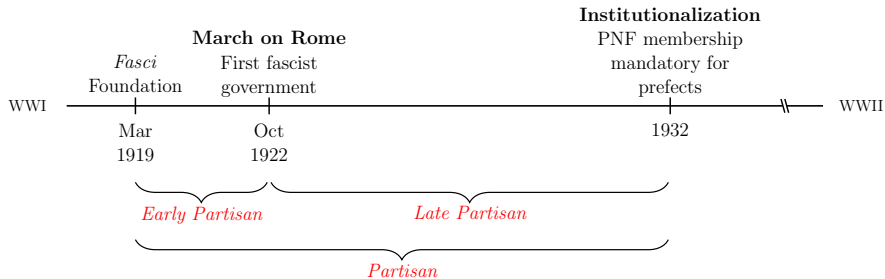


Figure 5: Voluntary Party Members as Partisans

Data

Digitizations

Explanatory variables:

- OCR'd *prefect biographies* from Cifelli (1999),
→ 414 prefects.

d'EUFEMIA nob. ing. Angelo¹

Nato a Napoli il 16 aprile 1888 Laureato in Ingegneria Civile. Ingegnere. Dirigente dei Sindacati Fascisti (Firenze). Nominato prefetto di 2ª classe il 16 settembre 1927² e prefetto di 1ª classe il 14 settembre 1934.

Grand'Ufficiale dell'Ordine della Corona d'Italia. Commendatore dell'Ordine Mauriziano.

Iscritto al P.N.F. dal marzo 1921.

Antemarcia. Brevetto Marcia su Roma. Squadrista. Sciarpa Littorio. Seniore della M.V.S.N. dall'agosto 1938.

Prefetto di Vercelli (settembre 1927 - aprile 1932), Savona (aprile 1932 - luglio 1935), Aosta (luglio 1935 - agosto 1939). A disposizione e incaricato di esercitare le funzioni ispettive (agosto 1939 - febbraio 1940) e dall'agosto 1939 Regio Commissario presso l'Ospedale di S. Maria Nuova in Firenze. Prefetto di Messina (febbraio 1940 - aprile 1943). A disposizione (aprile 1943 - febbraio 1944) con l'incarico di Direttore Generale per i Servizi di Guerra (aprile 1943 - gennaio 1944) e dal gennaio 1944 di Commissario per l'Amministrazione straordinaria dell'Istituto S. Michele di Roma.

Collocato a riposo per ragioni di servizio dal Governo fascista nel febbraio 1944.

Incaricato della Direzione dell'Ufficio Staccato in Roma dei Servizi di Guerra dal 20 febbraio 1944 (R.S.I.)³.

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→ 90 provinces, 18 years.

PROVINCIA DI AOSTA

La provincia fu istituita con r.d.l. 2 gennaio 1927, n. 1, con parte del territorio della provincia di Torino. Con d.l.lg. 7 settembre 1945, n. 545, la provincia fu soppressa e il territorio della Valle d'Aosta fu costituito in circoscrizione autonoma con capoluogo Aosta - a decorrere dalla data della restituzione della provincia all'amministrazione italiana - retta da un consiglio elettivo al cui presidente furono assegnate la rappresentanza della Valle e le attribuzioni conferite dalla legge al prefetto ed al presidente della deputazione provinciale.

PIRRETTI Stefano, dott., vice prefetto, 16 dicembre 1926 - 16 luglio 1929 nominato prefetto di Sondrio
SALVETTI Giacomo, dott., prefetto di Arezzo, 16 luglio 1929 - 10 agosto 1930 collocato a riposo per ragioni di servizio
PIETRAMISSA Pietro Paolo, dott., vice prefetto, 10 agosto 1930 - 25 ottobre 1931 nominato prefetto di Trento
NEGRİ Umberto, dott., vice prefetto, 25 ottobre 1931 - 25 luglio 1935 collocato a disposizione
D'EUFRASIA Angelo, ing., prefetto di Savona, 25 luglio 1935 - 21 agosto 1939 collocato a disposizione
CHIARIOTTI Pietro, dott., vice prefetto, 21 agosto 1939 - 1° giugno 1941 collocato a disposizione
SIGNORELLI Luigi, dott., prefetto a disposizione, 6 giugno 1941 - 15 settembre 1943 nominato prefetto di Sondrio
GARRETTI Ottavio, dott., prefetto a disposizione, 15 settembre 1943 - 25 ottobre 1943 collocato a disposizione (RSI)

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Outcome variable:

- *Individual-level political police records* from the Political Police Archive (see Panza et al. 2025, Dipoppa & Pezone 2025)
→ almost 100-thousand potential dissidents surveilled.



Raw Trends

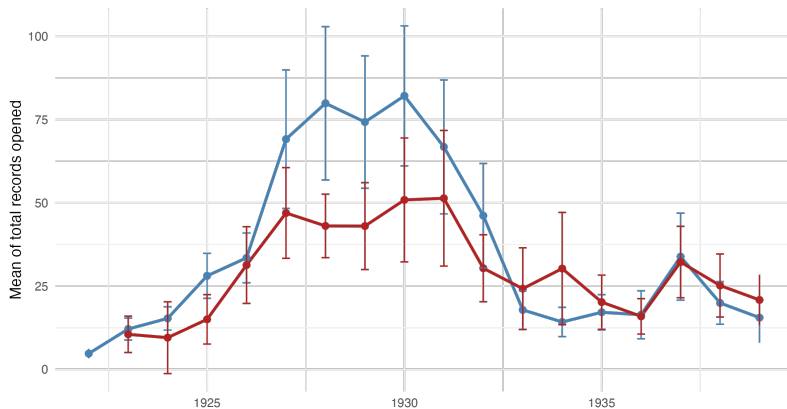


Figure 6: Annual means of records opened each year in provinces with **partisan** and **non-partisan** prefects in office.

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Treatment: a partisan prefect is assigned to the province (duration-weighted: 0 to 1 year share)

Outcome: number of political surveillance records opened per province-year.

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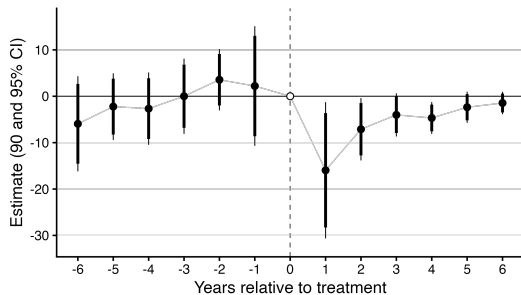
Staggered DiD à la de Chaisemartin and D'Haultfœuille (2024), on not-yet-treated.

Accounts for:

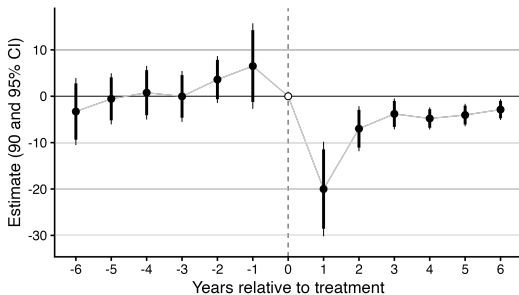
- continuous treatment,
- staggered treatment adoption,
- and treatment exit.

Parallel trends violated if partisans are assigned to locations where opposition is anticipated to weaken. [Alternative explanations](#)

Staggered DiD - Results



(a) Any Partisan.



(b) Early Partisans.

Figure 7: Effect of Receiving a Partisan Prefect on Surveillance Level ($\downarrow \sim 20\%$)

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- **Mere turnover:**

Only significant when the incoming prefect is a loyalist.

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Non-partisans put in more effort to reveal their loyalty.

- Non-partisans go after the usual suspects (empirical implication from Luo and Zakharov 2025).

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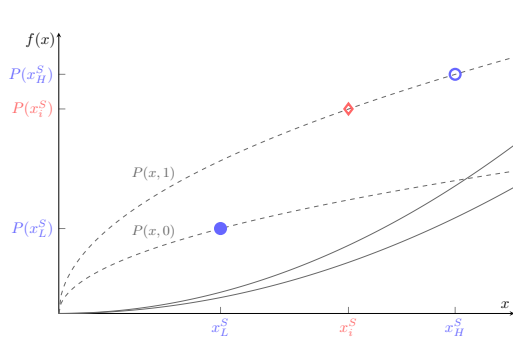
Suspects

- Non-partisans are rewarded less per record opened [today]

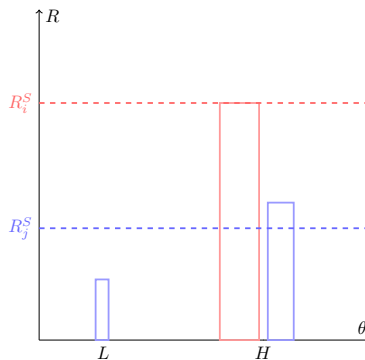
Signalling

Implication 2 - Returns to effort

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(a) Signalling Equilibrium



(b) Returns Per Record

↑ *returns* for **partisans** are only consistent with the *signalling* case.

Implication 2 - Returns to effort: Test

We fit a simple interacted model:

$$\text{Retain Office}_{i,p,m} = \beta_1 \text{Records}_{i,p,m} + \beta_2 \text{Early Partisan}_{i,p,m} \\ + \beta_3 \text{Records}_{i,p,m} \times \text{Early Partisan}_{i,p,m} + \phi_p + \gamma_m + \varepsilon_{i,p,m}$$

- Prefect i in province p at mandate m
- ϕ_p Province and γ_m Mandate number FE
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If *Signalling* is true, we expect:

- $\beta_1 > 0$: surveillance makes it more likely to be reappointed,
- $\beta_3 > 0$: and more so for early partisans.

→ credentials and performance are complements (à la Jia, Kudamatsu, and Seim 2015).

Implication 2 - Returns to effort: Test

Table 1: Early Partisans Gain More Job Security from Surveillance

Dependent Variable:	Retain Office					
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	OLS	OLS	Logit	OLS	OLS	Logit
<i>Variables</i>						
Records	0.001*** (0.000)	0.001*** (0.000)	0.009*** (0.003)	0.001** (0.000)	0.001*** (0.000)	0.007*** (0.002)
Early Partisan				-0.088 (0.069)	-0.092 (0.070)	-0.508 (0.382)
Early Partisan × Records				0.005*** (0.001)	0.005*** (0.001)	0.029** (0.011)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>						
Province	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mandate number		Yes	Yes		Yes	Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>						
Dependent variable mean	0.599	0.599	0.609	0.599	0.599	0.609
Observations	780	780	767	780	780	767
Adjusted R ²	0.025	0.027		0.031	0.033	
F-test	14.167	1.344		5.067	1.220	

Clustered (Province) standard-errors in parentheses. Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1

Implication 2 - Returns to effort: Test

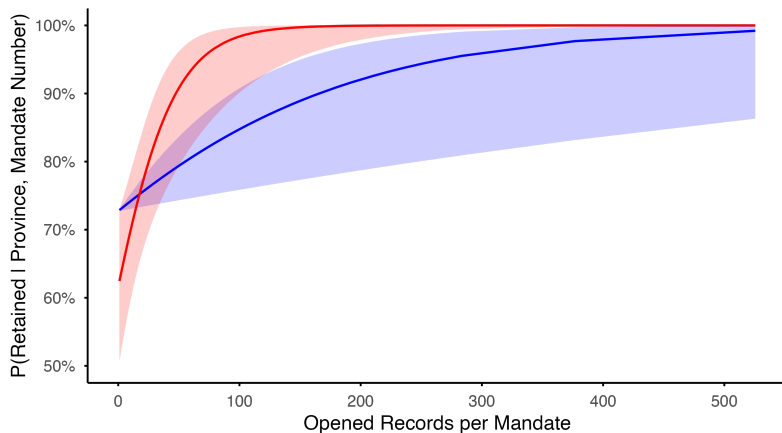


Figure 9: **Early Partisans** Gain More Job Security per Record

Conclusion

Contribution

1. No models directly focused on effort and political credentials:

→ *trust v. motivation* trade-off

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→ highest decentralized level, very different context + original dataset

Contribution

1. No models directly focused on effort and political credentials:
→ *trust v. motivation trade-off*
2. Lack of evidence on high-level bureaucrats outside of China and the US (Brierley et al. 2023):
→ *highest decentralized level, very different context + original dataset*
3. Surveillance literature focused on:
 - digital technologies (King, Pan, and Roberts 2013; Xu 2021; Beraja et al. 2023)
 - and on the watched (Dipoppa and Pezone 2025; Hager and Krakowski 2022)→ *focus on offline surveillance and on the watchers*

Takeaways

The case of surveillance in fascist Italy suggests that:

- appointing partisans does not necessarily lead to more forceful implementation of sensitive policies
- as partisan prefects surveilled the opposition less than their counterparts.
- This seems to be due to signaling incentives, based on:
 - effort as a costly signal,
 - higher priors of alignment for partisans.

→ signalling alignment is a major determinant of bureaucratic behaviour,

→ underscores a facet of the banality of evil (Arendt, 1963)

Thank you!

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Appendix

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Descriptives: Explanatory Variable

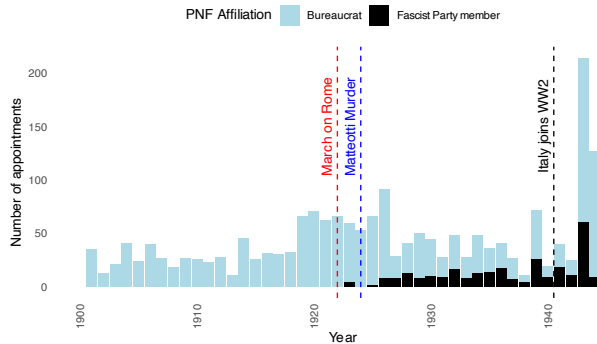


Figure 10: Loyalist Appointments

Descriptives: Partisans and ability proxies

		Non-partisans (N=320)		Partisans (N=90)	
		Mean	Std. Dev.	Mean	Std. Dev.
Age at start		52.8	5.8	45.2	7.0
Birth year		1876.6	9.0	1892.3	7.4
University		1.0	0.2	0.8	0.4
		N	Pct.	N	Pct.
Education	Diploma	5	1.6	9	10.0
	License	2	0.6	4	4.4
	Other	4	1.2	9	10.0
	University Degree	309	96.6	68	75.6

Descriptives: Outcome Variable

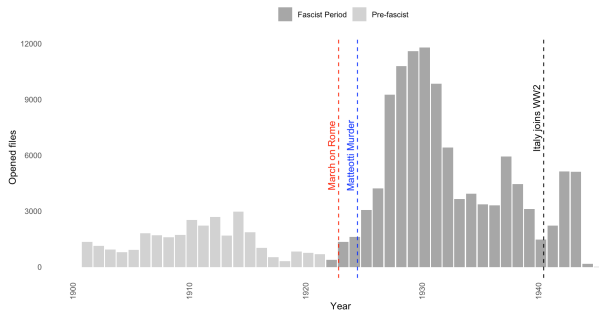


Figure 11: Surveillance Records

Back

Two-Way Fixed Effects

Table 2: Early Fascists Police Less Relative To Career Administrators

	Number of Police Records Opened			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Voluntary Member	-5.622** (2.480)		-5.468** (2.687)	
Early Member		-6.845** (2.641)		-6.284** (2.860)
Late Member		2.194 (6.387)		-0.087 (6.560)
Restricted Sample			✓	✓
Dependent variable mean	31.057	31.057	31.766	31.766
Observations	1,794	1,794	1,412	1,412
Adjusted R ²	0.613	0.614	0.619	0.619
F-test	6.033	5.825	6.348	6.120
Province fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Year fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓

Standard errors are clustered at the province level.

, **, and * correspond to 10, 5, and 1% levels of significance, respectively.*

Complete values

Table 3: Early Partisans Surveil Less Relative To Career Administrators

	Number of Records Opened			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Any Partisan	-4.741*		-5.356**	
	(2.535)		(2.678)	
Early Partisan		-6.063**		-6.180**
		(2.716)		(2.849)
Late Partisan		4.849		1.401
		(6.359)		(6.585)
Restricted Sample			✓	✓
Dependent variable mean	30.877	30.944	31.367	31.450
Observations	1,611	1,597	1,382	1,368
Adjusted R ²	0.610	0.611	0.613	0.613
F-test	6.034	5.843	6.230	6.021
Province fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Year fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓

Standard errors are clustered at the province level.

, **, and * correspond to 10, 5, and 1% levels of significance, respectively.*

Mere Turnover

Table 4: Mere Turnover Does Not Drive the Result

Dependent Variable: Model:	Number of Records Opened			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
<i>Variables</i>				
Any Change	-1.632 (1.553)	-1.618 (1.546)	-0.759 (2.202)	-0.809 (2.206)
Voluntary Member	-5.712** (2.493)		-5.532** (2.683)	
Early Member		-6.939** (2.657)		-6.364** (2.856)
Late Member		2.009 (6.394)		-0.160 (6.559)
Restricted Sample			✓	✓
<i>Fixed-effects</i>				
Province	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>				
Dependent variable mean	31.057	31.057	31.766	31.766
Observations	1,794	1,794	1,412	1,412
Adjusted R ²	0.613	0.614	0.618	0.618
F-test	5.815	5.622	6.114	5.903

Clustered (Province) standard-errors in parentheses

Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1

Mechanism: Competence

Table 5: Early Partisans Police Less Controlling for Competence Proxies

	Number of Records Opened			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Early Partisan	-7.291** (2.791)	-6.355** (2.665)	-6.865** (2.638)	-6.154** (2.930)
Late Partisan	2.006 (6.457)	1.783 (6.391)	2.515 (6.475)	2.152 (6.455)
Has a Degree	-2.120 (3.452)			-1.963 (3.466)
Years of Experience		-0.538 (0.605)		-1.288 (1.341)
Current Mandate Number			0.583 (0.769)	2.020 (2.100)
Dependent variable mean	31.057	31.057	31.057	31.057
Observations	1,794	1,794	1,794	1,794
Adjusted R ²	0.613	0.614	0.614	0.616
F-test	5.619	5.637	5.625	5.317
Province fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Year fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓

*, **, and *** correspond to 10, 5, and 1% levels of significance, respectively.

Standard errors are clustered at the province level.

Mechanism: Preferential deployment

- Fascist prefects might be more “upwardly embedded” (Torralba, 2024)
- and sent to easier locations,
- but we cannot measure waning opposition.

We assume prefects prefer to be deployed in provinces which are:

- closer to home
 - we calculate distance from birthplace,
- more prestigious
 - we calculate the likelihood prefects in the province became MPs (in the Liberal Era).

Mechanism: Preferential deployment

Table 6: Loyalists Are Not Deployed to Better Places

Dependent Variables: Model:	(1)	Birthplace Distance		(4)	Prestige Score	
		(2)	(3)		(5)	(6)
<i>Variables</i>						
Any Partisan	-17.950 (22.068)	-14.006 (23.416)			0.005 (0.006)	
Early Partisan			-16.620 (24.546)	-12.933 (25.834)		0.001 (0.006)
Late Partisan			-26.324 (38.702)	-20.802 (37.602)		0.032*** (0.007)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>						
Province	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes		
Mandate number		Yes		Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>						
Dependent variable mean	433.264	433.264	433.264	433.264	0.158	0.158
Observations	788	788	788	788	800	800
Adjusted R ²	0.049	0.047	0.047	0.046	0.111	0.111
F-test	18.037	1.634	9.020	1.509	1.565	0.791

Mechanism: Deterrence

That streets are peaceful does not mean there is no violence.

(in Przeworski, 2015, p. 249)

- If early partisans had a harsh reputation,
- the opposition might go underground once they are appointed,

→ prefects might surveil less because insurgent activity is reduced.

If this is the case, they might have built that reputation by **opening more records initially** and much less later.

Mechanism: Deterrence

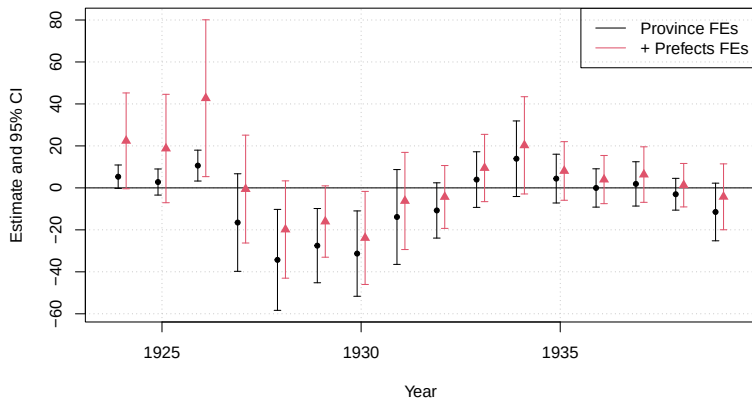


Figure 12: Early Partisans Building a Harsh Reputation?

Mechanism: Deterrence

Table 7: Early Surveillance Does Not Seem to Build Deterrence

Dependent Variable:	Number of Records Opened							
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
<i>Variables</i>								
Early Surveillance	0.369*** (0.107)	0.371*** (0.103)	0.375*** (0.111)	0.384*** (0.100)	0.362*** (0.117)	0.384*** (0.105)	0.362*** (0.119)	0.391*** (0.099)
Any Partisan	-9.329*** (3.179)	-8.899** (3.504)			-8.978*** (3.103)	-8.064** (3.509)		
Early Surveillance × Any Partisan	0.091 (0.213)	0.163 (0.198)			0.050 (0.201)	0.116 (0.186)		
Early Partisan			-9.443*** (3.456)	-8.966** (3.873)			-9.209*** (3.341)	-8.229** (3.857)
Late Partisan			-7.276 (6.025)	-5.345 (5.619)			-7.949 (5.907)	-5.666 (5.252)
Early Surveillance × Early Partisan			0.074 (0.245)	0.104 (0.249)			0.078 (0.246)	0.095 (0.254)
Restricted Sample					✓	✓	✓	✓
<i>Fixed-effects</i>								
Province	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mandate Number		Yes		Yes		Yes		Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>								
Dependent variable mean	32.599	32.599	32.599	32.599	32.401	32.401	32.401	32.401
Observations	567	567	567	567	506	506	506	506
Adjusted R ²	0.570	0.579	0.569	0.578	0.569	0.583	0.568	0.582
F-test	52.757	13.000	39.551	12.048	54.588	13.729	40.951	12.738

Mechanism: Embeddedness

- More local prefects might surveil more efficiently (Scott, 1998; Mattingly, 2019)
- Yet fascist prefects are not deployed closer to home,
- and embeddedness is not associated with less surveillance

Mechanism: Embeddedness

Table 8: More Local Prefects Do Not Surveil Less

Dependent Variable: Model:	(1)	(2)	Records Opened		(5)	(6)
			(3)	(4)		
<i>Variables</i>						
Birthplace Distance	-0.003 (0.005)	-0.004 (0.005)	-0.004 (0.006)	-0.005 (0.006)	-0.004 (0.006)	-0.005 (0.006)
Birthplace Distance $\times$ Any Partisan			0.012 (0.009)	0.012 (0.009)		
Birthplace Distance $\times$ Early Partisan					0.013 (0.009)	0.012 (0.009)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>						
Province	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mandate Number		Yes		Yes		Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>						
Dependent variable mean	30.201	30.201	30.201	30.201	30.201	30.201
Observations	751	751	751	751	751	751
Adjusted R ²	0.485	0.486	0.484	0.486	0.483	0.485
F-test	105.705	9.144	35.344	7.861	26.522	7.340

Mechanism: Testable Implications of Signaling

- Luo and Zakharov (2025) predict efficiency-signaling through the targeting of most likely (ethnic) opponents,
- because ethnicity is observable by the dictator.

Mechanism: Testable Implications of Signaling

- Luo and Zakharov (2025) predict efficiency-signaling through the targeting of most likely (ethnic) opponents,
- because ethnicity is observable by the dictator.
- As ethnicity is not relevant in our context, we classify most likely opponents as working-class individuals (low-skilled jobs + unemployed)
- and check mediation:

Table 9: Early Partisans effect is entirely mediated by low-skill targets.

Effect	Estimate	95% CI
ACME (indirect)	-7.24	[-11.26 ; -3.73]
ADE (direct)	0.27	[-1.14 ; 1.76]
Total effect	-6.97	[-10.85 ; -3.56]

Notes: Two-equation OLS with province and year fixed effects. ACME = average causal mediation effect; ADE = average direct effect.

- might also be the easiest opponents to *'invent'*